

Hangouts – none of which were particularly ground breaking on their own. If Google hoped that the whole would be greater than the sum of the parts, they were sadly mistaken as Hangouts never got widespread adoption. Hangouts is an instant messaging tool with several other functionalities like audio and video calls built in, which is linked to everyone's Gmail and Google+ accounts. People could send requests to other users in their email contacts and once accepted, could start instantly messaging them or calling them. While users in a large business environment who had to communicate with a lot of people on a daily basis but couldn't spare the time to hunt down everyone's personal IDs for different IM apps found Hangouts a huge blessing, at the same time, mainstream public preferred other IM apps even at the expense of a few more hoops to jump through perhaps because of the UI... or the lack thereof. Now don't get us wrong, Hangouts has a very functional user interface but when you compare to something like Facebook Messenger or Whatsapp, it looks absolutely outdated and spartan. Google also tried forcing adoption rates up by sneakily making Hangouts the default messaging app on stock Android devices but even that failed to provide any significant traction, dooming Hangouts to business user obscurity. Perhaps something like a Material Design overhaul on Hangouts with easier ways to integrate it would boost usage rates but with people being so deeply entrenched with apps like Whatsapp and Telegram, we fear that Hangouts is doomed to a slow death.

Allo and Duo

Perhaps disappointed with Hangouts' less than spectacular reception, Google made another valiant effort at capturing the instant messaging space. Allo and Duo were sister apps announced in May of last year. Allo is an instant messaging service with AI baked in. As with other conventional IM apps, people are identified with phone numbers instead of social media accounts or email addresses. But that's where the similarities with other apps end. Allo packs in a whole lot of new features such as the 'WhisperShout', which lets you change the size of the message to emphasize or demphasize its content. But by far it's biggest feature is the smart reply. It can suggest replies based on your previous message history, allowing you to respond much faster to mundane questions that you have to deal with often. What's more, it can even detect the mood of the message and suggest smileys! We are truly in the future. Google also touted Allo as a very secure messaging platform by storing messages in "transiently and in non-identifiable form"